

FOR DECADES, Indian workplaces ran on an unspoken bargain: show up, stay loyal, wait your turn and success will follow. Generation Z, Gen Z or Zoomers, never signed that contract.

By 2025, India's Gen Z population (those born between 1997 and 2012) stood at an estimated 377 million, according to the BCG-Snapchat report *The \$2 Trillion Opportunity: How Gen Z Is Shaping the New India*. Once on the margins, Gen Z has now moved firmly into the workforce mainstream, already accounting for one in four workers. The report estimates this share will reach 36% by 2030 and nearly half the workforce (47%) by 2035.

And employers are being forced to confront an uncomfortable truth: the old rules are no longer working.

conditions have fundamentally reshaped how this generation evaluates work.

Rather than prioritising long hours or rigid hierarchies, Gen Z places greater value on learning, clear career progression, purpose, and flexibility. Roles are assessed not only on pay but on growth potential, quality of mentorship, team culture, and alignment with organisational values alongside expectations of modern ways of working.

This is reflected in the BT-PRICE Gen Z Consumption Behaviour Survey, which shows that salary growth and financial security (28%) and role or career progression (28%) remain top job drivers. Job security (17%) matters among lower-income cohorts, while work-life balance (14%) and flexibility (9%) grow in importance as financial stability improves.

Location remains the least influential factor overall, reinforcing Gen Z's digital-first expectations.

For employers, this marks a fundamental shift in the talent equation. Das notes that Gen Z is vocal, research-driven, and quick to move on when expectations around growth, recognition, or culture are not met. Merit-based advancement is preferred over seniority, leaders

are expected to be digitally fluent, and managers are valued more as coaches than controllers.

Randstad's *The Gen Z Workplace Blueprint* echoes this, describing Indian Zoomers as financially ambitious yet purpose-seeking, technologically confident yet anxious about career stability. Careers increasingly blend full-time roles with side hustles, short tenures, and AI-enabled learning creating both opportunity and volatility for employers.

What unsettles many organisations is not what Gen Z wants but how it behaves while pursuing it.

NERVOUS EMPLOYERS

Moonlighting. Job-hopping. Micro-retirements. Bare-minimum Mondays. Coffee-badging. To many leaders, these appear as warning signs of disengagement. But data suggests they may instead be symptoms of a workforce adapting faster than organisational systems.

According to Indeed's 2025 *Workplace Trends Report*, 42% of employers interpret behaviours like job-hopping or brief office appearances (often dubbed coffee-badging), or quiet quitting as signs of disengagement. In contrast, 62% of employees see them as pragmatic strategies to manage careers, navigate uncertainty, and protect well-being. These often coexist with high performance. Younger employees are increasingly optimising for learning velocity, seeking environments where skills compound quickly, exposure is broad, and feedback is immediate.

The shift is particularly pronounced among younger workers. Nearly 68% of entry- to junior-level employees say they are actively experimenting with new approaches to learning and career planning. Around 40% report blending work with side hustles, flexible schedules, or short career breaks. In total, 75% have adopted at least one "modern work behaviour."

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Gen Z entered the workforce amid overlapping disruptions: a pandemic, economic volatility, rapid digitisation, and now artificial intelligence (AI)-led transformation. According to Anshuman Das, Chief Executive Officer and Co-founder of recruitment services firm Careernet, these

While many employers believe they understand Gen Z, execution often tells a different story. Zoomers place far less value on fixed structures and formal hierarchies